



M GROUP

Environmental handbook

Version 2.0 February 2026

Essential infrastructure
services for life

M Group Water aims to operate with environmental integrity and has made significant progress in its approach to environmental impact management. Our aim is to go

beyond compliance by preventing pollution, complying with legislation and maintaining continual improvement.

This handbook provides our people with information on the environmental issues that affect our work and gives guidance on the steps that need to be taken to ensure our operations are conducted in compliance with legal requirements and good practice standards.

Environmental strategy

Our strategic environmental targets are:

- Retain ISO 14001 accreditation across all operations.
- Enhance reporting and measurement of Carbon (to include willing supply chain partners).
- Waste
- Recycling
- Fuel and carbon emissions reduction.

The handbook is structured into colour coded sections containing guidance on:

Water
pollution

The local
environment

Waste

Wildlife and
protected areas

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Water pollution

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Why it's important

Petrol, diesel and oil are all highly harmful to plants, animals and humans and can give rise to pollution of the environment.

Such substances are released into the environment through spillages during delivery or use or through waste materials being poured directly to drains or gullies.

Storage of oil is subject to specific legal minimum standards. If pollution is caused then prosecution may follow. The cost of clean up and legal proceedings following a spillage incident far exceeds the cost of putting proper controls in place.



Do

General

- Store oils away from drains or watercourses.
- Return oil and fuels to storage areas after use.
- Locate oil stores away from areas of high vehicular movement to prevent accidental damage.
- Bund individual 205 litre drums to 25%.
- Supervise all fuel deliveries.
- Lock oil stores or bowzers when not in use.
- Use drip trays under all static plant and during refuelling from mobile plant.

Bulk storage

- Bund tanks and bowzers to 110%.
- Regular checks to ensure bunds are free from cracks and leaks.
- Regularly empty bunds and drip trays of rainwater, which should be treated as contaminated.
- Keep all hoses and pipe work within bunded area after use.
- Keep a spill kit near to fuel and oil storage areas and refuelling areas.
- Report any irregularities or incidents.

Don't

- Refuel or store oil within 10m of watercourses or surface water drains.
- Leave bunds and drip trays to overflow.
- Leave refuelling hoses outside of bunds after use.
- Use high pressure delivery systems when filling small containers.

Do

- Always put lids on any containers after use.
- Use the automatic shut off “pistol grip” delivery systems when refuelling from tanks or mobile bowser – do not tamper with the shut off system at any time.
- Ensure that all refuelling is constantly attended and only undertaken at least 10m away from watercourses and drains.
- Clean up any minor spillages.
- Use funnels when refuelling small plant and equipment to avoid spillages.
- Use plant nappies or drip trays under all plant or equipment that contains fuel or oils.
- Ensure that a fully stocked spill kit is easily accessible at all work sites.

Disposal

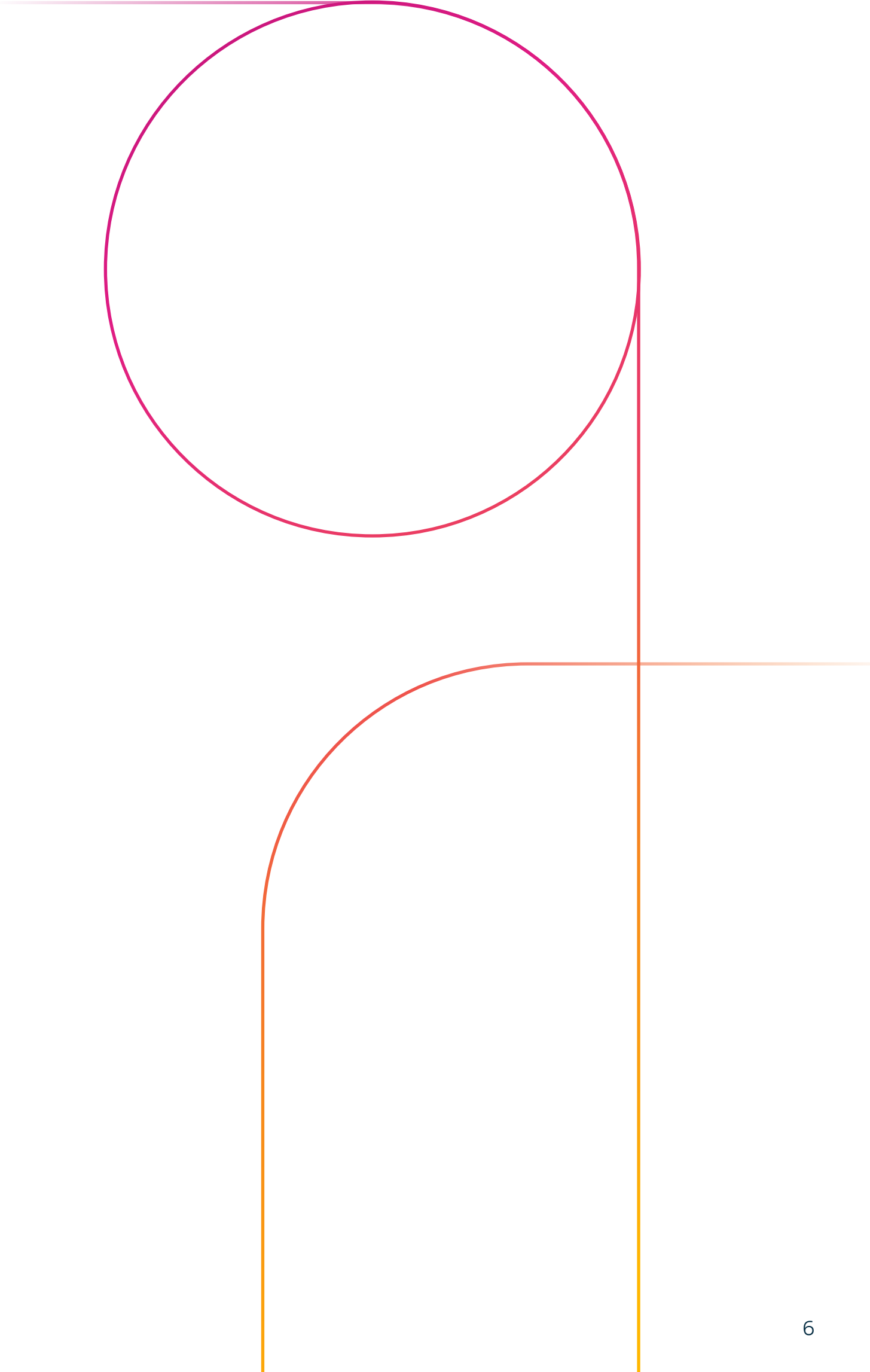
- Ask your manager what to do with waste oil, petrol and diesel and any materials contaminated with such substances, prior to any disposal.

Don't

- Leave refuelling operations unattended at any time.
- Leave containers open when unused.
- Leave containers in an area where they can be damaged.

Disposal

- Pour petrol, diesel or waste oil down drains or gullies.
- Try to dispose of petrol, diesel or waste oils by setting fire to them.
- Dispose of used spill kits in general waste, place them only in a hazardous waste container.



Why it's important

Water contaminated with cement is highly alkaline and can be toxic to fish, plants and animals living in watercourses. Cement particles entering a watercourse can clog fishes' gills and also destroy their spawning grounds.

It's illegal to allow cement, unset concrete or washout water containing cement to enter a watercourse or drain.

Special permission is needed before construction work can take place in a watercourse.



Do

- Identify all watercourses, gullies and drains prior to commencing work.
- Store bulk and bagged cement and concrete additives at least 10 metres away from watercourses, gullies and drains.
- Undertake mixing/batching works well away from watercourses and drains.
- Use only designated areas for concrete washout.
- Where necessary protect nearby drains against washout water running into them.
- **Notify** your manager **immediately** if you see any concrete spillages or concrete washout likely to cause pollution.

Don't

- Hose down spills of concrete or cement into surface water drains.
- Allow washout water to flow into any watercourse or drain.
- Allow ready-mix trucks to washout anywhere other than in safe areas designated for the purpose.
- Wash off any tools or plant in watercourses.

Why it’s important

High levels of silt suspended in water can suffocate fish by blocking their gills, can remove essential oxygen from the water and can kill plants, animals and insects living in the water by stopping sunlight.

Because of the potential for harm, it’s illegal to allow silt to enter a watercourse or drain.

Silt pollution spoils the appearance of watercourses, is easily traceable to the site from where it originated and, in the past, has been a major cause of prosecution.



Do

- Only discharge silty water into designated settlement systems or through a filter.
- Check that site drainage and settlement systems are working - discolouration may indicate high pollutant loading.
- Stop pumping and contact your manager if you think a problem is arising.
- Ensure that all hard standings are kept clean – notify your manager if an area is silty or is covered in mud.
- Notify your manager immediately if you see silty water entering a watercourse or drain and do try to stop it or divert it away by, for example, using sand bags.

Don’t

- Dewater any excavation without getting permission from your manager.
- Pump silty water directly into rivers, ditches or surface water drains.
- Strip land of vegetation unless it’s absolutely necessary – vegetation reduces silt run-off.
- Store soil, stone or similar materials within 10 metres of watercourses or drains.
- Dig a grip to release ponded water to a watercourse or drain.

Why it's important

In the UK, pumping and overpumping are common techniques used in construction dewatering to manage groundwater and surface water during excavations. Sump pumping, a simple method, involves collecting water in sumps and pumping it away. Overpumping, on the other hand, provides a temporary bypass for water flow, often around structures like manholes. These techniques are crucial for maintaining a stable and safe excavation site, preventing issues like soil instability and potential damage to adjacent structures.



Do

- Check with your line manager whether any treatment systems are required before final discharge of pumped out water.
- Utilise a suitable system, which include settlement tanks, discharge over grassed areas, through silt socks or hay bales.
- Check that the point of discharge is to the correct location, that is to the sewer, manhole or gully as set out by your line manager.
- Check that all couplings and other pipework fittings are secure.
- Examine, inspect and regularly check that any treatment systems are working, water being finally discharged is clear of silt or solids and is not causing damage to the bed or banks of any watercourse.
- **Notify** your line manager **immediately** if you notice: pollution (muddy water, oils etc) occurring; the discharge causing flooding; or any pipework is damaged, or connections have broken or are leaking.
- Ensure appropriate pump size and discharge rate: Use a pump that is appropriately sized for the job and discharge rate to avoid causing erosion of riverbeds or banks. Discharge should be made at a rate that will not disturb the excavation floor.
- Ensure workers are trained in the safe use of pumping equipment, and that the equipment is monitored for leaks and spills.
- Be aware of the legal requirements for water discharge activities, especially if discharging into surface water. Dewatering activities may require an abstraction license under the Water Resources Act 1990 if more than 20m³/day is removed.

Don't

Don't disturb the Excavation Floor.

When pumping, be careful not to disturb the bottom of the excavation, as this can stir up silt and potentially introduce hydrocarbons or other pollutants into the pumped water.

- If the excavation is suspected of being contaminated, have samples tested before pumping to determine if special treatment is needed.
- If the site or water within the excavation is suspected of being contaminated, it is crucial to have samples taken and tested before pumping.
- If contamination is severe, a vacuum tanker may be needed, but a sediment filter can help process most of the water first.
- Operate machinery in the excavation before dewatering is complete can lead to leaks or spills of oil or other pollutants into the water.

Washing down plant and machinery

Why it's important

Washing down plant and machinery, hosing down concrete trucks/mixers or degreasing engines can all lead to serious pollution incidents if it's not properly carried out. The resulting dirty water should not be allowed to enter surface water drains or road gullies. Careful consideration must be given to where washing down is carried out.

Dirty washing and rinsing water may contain dislodged mud, grease, oils, detergents, cleaning agents or toxic chemicals and materials that can kill fish and other aquatic life and which may also seriously affect the surrounding environment.

It's illegal to allow polluting matter such as silt, cement, concrete, fuel, oils, cleaning chemicals and detergents to enter a watercourse or a drain.

Do

- Ask your manager if there's a place specially designated for washing down plant and machinery.
- Use only these designated wash down areas whenever they are provided.
- Ensure that any wash down slurry or residue is contained and cannot enter drains or watercourses.
- Check with your manager before using degreasing or cleansing solutions – don't just assume they can be used.
- Report to your manager any washing down that may cause a pollution incident.

Don't

- Wash down before finding out the proper place in which to do it.
- Wash down directly into watercourses or surface water drains.
- Allow dirty wash down water to go down roadside gullies.
- Wash down near material or storage areas or immediately next to working areas.
- Use any more water than is necessary – reduce waste.

Why it's important

Bentonite is a type of clay that swells and gels when dispersed in water. It acts like a liquid when agitated or stirred and like a solid when left at rest.

As "mud" it's used as a lubricant when drilling or pipe pushing and as "slurry" it's used to fill and support the sides of excavations during the construction of diaphragm walls, cut-off walls, or piles. The use of bentonite can lead to spillage around operational areas and around mixing, pumping and storage equipment. Liquid bentonite is highly polluting and if it enters watercourses or drains can give rise to damage to plants and animals in watercourses. Pollution of watercourses by bentonite may lead to prosecution.

If not correctly managed, bentonite in powder form can become airborne causing dust nuisance to local residents leading to legal action by the Local Authority.



Do

- Keep dry powder or granule containers closed to prevent dust or damage by rain or moisture.
- Ensure that bentonite does not spill onto the ground.
- Ensure that if spillages do occur they are promptly cleared up.
- Protect watercourses and drains from any spillage of liquid bentonite.
- Report immediately to your manager any incidents where bentonite is seen entering a watercourse or a drain, or is becoming airborne.
- Ask your manager what to do with waste bentonite.

Don't

- Leave containers or bags containing bentonite open to the air.
- Ignore spillages on the ground.
- Intentionally allow liquid or powdered bentonite to spill onto the ground.
- Pour bentonite into watercourses or drains.
- Give bentonite away to third parties without checking with your manager.

Why it's important

Accidental releases of oils and chemicals from construction-sites make up a large number of pollution incidents that occur each year, polluting water courses and contaminating land and groundwater.

Substances we use that could cause harm if spilled include: fuel, oils, paints, solvents, antifreeze, concrete. Spills spread very quickly and lead to environmental harm. Fines and clean up costs can be expensive and even individuals can be held responsible.



Do

- Understand where drains go. (Surface water and foul water drains are different).
- Know emergency measures and spill kit locations.
- Cover drains before spills occur.
- **Stop work** immediately.
- Immediately report spills, equipment leaks and any environmental damage.
- Take care to avoid spills in all operations, particularly with hazardous substances.
- Supervise all deliveries.
- Know and abide by discharge activity environmental permit.
- Store and unload liquids within bunded areas.
- Follow EMS procedures for emergency discharges.
- If spillage is flammable, extinguish all possible sources of ignition.
- Identify the source of pollution and rectify the problem.
- Contain the spillage – on land use socks, earth or sand to construct a bund around the spill to stop it spreading. Use booms to contain oil spills that have already entered a watercourse.
- Contact your Line Manager.
- Put on appropriate PPE – typically rubber gloves.
- Protect sensitive areas (e.g. watercourses or surface water drains – use drain covers or use earth/sand to construct a bund).
- Clean up the spill. Use absorbent granules/pads to mop up spills. Large pools of oil or spills which cannot be absorbed should be removed by gulper.
- Dispose of all contaminated materials correctly – those containing substances such as oil, diesel or paint will be hazardous waste. Ensure any contaminated water is taken to an appropriately licensed disposal site.
- Notify your line manager of actions taken.

Don't

Don't ignore it! Stop work and act immediately.

- Wash silty or contaminated water into surface water drains or water courses.
- Pour waste liquids down drains or open gulleys – seek expert advice.
- Ignore an incident, worrying that it will be traced back to your work.
- Ignore an incident by a third party, assuming someone else is responsible and they will report it. Early response can limit the spread of pollutants.
- Skip steps or leave jobs that help manage spill risks thinking it won't be noticeable.
- Permit any unconsented discharges.
- Allow bunded areas to fill with rainwater (or waste liquid) – dispose of this appropriately.
- Risk your health and safety.
- Store materials on site for unnecessary lengths of time.

The local environment

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Why it's important

Being a good neighbour creates a positive image of the industry. If neighbours complain to their Local Authorities about dust or noise nuisance caused, the Local Authority can impose conditions and restrictions on working, which can lead to delays.

If any problems being caused by dust or aren't resolved the Local Authority can prosecute those responsible.

If good relations can be established with neighbours, many issues such as access to site, material deliveries and working hours can be improved through friendly negotiation.



Do

- Be polite and considerate to members of the public at all times.
- Take accurate notice of any complaint made by a neighbour and pass it on to your line manager.
- Only use approved routes to access the site.
- Use only designated parking areas, if they are provided, otherwise always park vehicles with consideration for the needs of others.
- Keep dust and noise to a minimum.
- Always close any noise reducing engine covers while plant is in use.
- Direct site lighting and task lighting away from neighbouring properties.
- Tell your line manager if rubbish bins or skips are full or nearly full.
- Notify your line manager immediately if you find any fly tipped waste in the area.

Don't

- Obstruct vehicle accesses or driveways to neighbouring properties.
- Obstruct public rights of way such as pavements, footpaths, bridleways.
- Drag mud onto the roads outside the site - make sure vehicle wheels are clean before leaving.
- Trespass on neighbour's land.
- Leave engines running unnecessarily.
- Shout on-site or have noisy radios on.
- Shout or whistle at passers-by.
- Drop litter or leave sites untidy.
- Leave gates to the site open.

Material handling and housekeeping

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Why it's important

Poor storage and handling of materials creates waste, which is a loss of resource and is very costly.

Poorly stored materials increase the risk of pollution incidents.

A tidy site is a safe site.

Good housekeeping creates a positive image to the general public.



Do

- Avoid double handling as much as possible: less effort, less damage, less wastage.
- Supervise the delivery of materials to ensure correct location and method of storage.
- Check that a material is fully used prior to starting a new batch.
- Return to storage any materials that have not been used.
- Use off-cuts where possible.
- Re-use formwork as often as practically possible.
- Designate an area for surplus concrete – it can be crushed and re-used.
- Pick up litter.

Don't

- Store or leave unprotected any materials that can be damaged by weather, e.g. cement bags.
- Over order materials.
- Put materials in a skip if they still have a use.
- Use new lengths of pipe or cable for short pieces of work. Minimise the need for off-cuts.
- Store together any materials that can contaminate each other.

Why it's important

Dust, emissions and odours can annoy neighbours and may cause health risks at very high concentrations, such as eye irritation or making asthma worse.

Dust can damage the ecology of a watercourse and affect plant growth, including crops.

The Local Authority has the power to stop works if dust is causing a nuisance. Emission of dark smoke from plant and fires is illegal.



Do

- Keep surfaces swept and damp down with water at regular intervals.
- Minimise drop heights into haulage vehicles and into conveyors.
- Ensure cutting and grinding operations are adequately shielded or wetted.
- Sheet lorries carrying dry materials off-site.
- Keep to site speed limits to minimise dust generation.
- Use the wheel wash, for appropriate vehicles, if one is provided on-site.
- Store fine, dry materials within buildings or provide adequate protection from the wind.
- Store bulk cement and bentonite in silos.
- Position silos and stockpiles away from residential areas or watercourses.
- Clean up or damp down any spillage of dry dusty materials.
- Notify your Line Manager if work activities are causing poor air quality.

Don't

- Burn materials on site without approval from your Project Manager. Permission is required first from the Environment Agency.
- Use poorly maintained plant. Black smoke may give rise to poor health and can cause a nuisance.
- Leave plant running if not in use.
- Ignore sources of poor air quality, notify your line manager.
- Ignore complaints.

Why it's important

The Construction Industry is one of the leading sources of noise complaints made to Local Authorities.

Noise and vibration emissions can disturb local residents and give rise to complaints and delays.

Noise can disturb wildlife as well as humans. Noisy activities include: excavation, tunnelling, concrete cutting, piling, using un-silenced generators and concrete pours.

The Local authority have the power to stop works if noise from the site is causing a nuisance. Failing to meet noise constraints can result in fines.



Do

If possible, restrict noisy activities to certain times of the day.

- Avoid double handling as much as possible: less effort, less damage, less wastage.
- Adhere to working hours. Some sites are only consented to work at certain times.
- Plan deliveries. Arrange routes and times to minimise potential nuisance to the local community.
- If possible, keep noisy plant away from public areas.
- Minimise drop heights into hoppers, lorries and other plant.
- Use local screening where necessary.
- Noise can be reduced if a screen is placed between plant and nearby sensitive locations e.g. houses. Screens can be straw bales or ply board.
- Use silenced generators and tower lights where necessary.
- Keep acoustic doors and hoods on plant closed – it does make a difference!
- Contact your Line Manager if you're in doubt about noisy activities.

Don't

- Undertake noisy works during the evening, at night or very early in the morning if it can be avoided!
- Leave doors and hoods open on plant.
- Leave plant running unnecessarily.
- Use poorly maintained plant.
- Ignore complaints from the local community.
- Undertake activities that could cause damage to nearby structures through vibration unless approved by your line manager.

Working on previously developed land

Why it's important

Land which has previously been built on or used by industrial processes (“brownfield land”) or which has in the past had imported material placed upon it (“made ground”) may be contaminated with substances which are harmful to humans, wildlife and / or the surrounding environment.

Since potentially contaminated material can sometimes be discovered where it’s not expected it’s always wise to remain observant during digging operations.

Exposure to certain contaminants may cause harm to health. Working in contaminated soils without the proper precautions and controls may result in pollution and/or harm spreading into the surrounding land, adjacent watercourses or into the atmosphere.

Do

Don't

- Always wear the correct protective clothing.
 - Wash your hands and all areas of exposed skin after working in made ground or brownfield land.
 - Look out for changes to the types of material being worked in which may show up as:
 - Differences in colour or texture.
 - The presence of refuse (rubbish) or other foreign objects.
 - Differences in smell - common contaminants such as oils, landfill gases and degrading waste have distinctive odours.
 - If you see changes like these **stop work** make the area safe and notify your Line Manager.
 - Prevent the spread of contaminated dust – either cover the source or damp it down.
- Smoke or eat whilst working in made ground.
 - Permit colleagues or other operatives to enter the contaminated land until your line manager instructs you to do so.
 - Smoke or eat whilst working in made ground.
 - Take off PPE.

Any pollution escaping from the site may lead to prosecution.



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Waste

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All businesses are required by law to comply with legislation that sets out how they must manage waste. The legislation applies to all waste producers, waste carriers, waste recyclers and waste disposal sites. It's referred to as the 'Duty of Care' for Waste and was introduced by the 1990 Environmental Protection Act.

Failing to follow the requirements of the Duty of Care is a criminal offence and could lead to the prosecution of M Group Water, sub-contractors and individual employees.

This section of the pack explains each of these three requirements as they apply to grab and support operations and gives simple guidance on what steps to take to ensure that the legal duties are adhered to.

The Duty of Care imposes three main requirements on any person who produces, carries, keeps, treats, or disposes of waste as follows:

- Preventing waste from escaping.
- Transfer only to legally authorised persons; and
- Provide a waste transfer note that gives a written description of the waste and meets minimum legal standards.

In addition to the Duty of Care, which applies to all wastes, there are extra duties that apply when waste is classed as hazardous and if classified under Street Works UK Protocol.

The waste duty of care requires businesses to responsibly manage their waste, ensuring it's handled and disposed of safely and legally. This involves preventing pollution, minimizing waste, and only using authorized waste carriers. Key actions include using registered waste carriers, completing waste transfer notes, and storing waste securely.

Failing to follow the requirements of the Duty of Care is a criminal offence and could lead to the prosecution of M Group Water, subcontractors and individual employees.

The Duty of Care legislation imposes three main requirements on any company or person who produces, carries, keeps, treats, or disposes of waste as follows:

- Prevent waste from escaping from site, skips and any other.
- Transfer only to legally authorised persons; and
- Provide a fully completed waste transfer note that gives a written description of the waste and meets minimum legal standards.

Do

- Use registered waste carriers: Ensure the company handling your waste is registered with the Environment Agency (or equivalent in your area).
- Check waste carrier's registration: Ask for their waste carrier number and verify it on the public register.
- Complete waste transfer notes: Keep records of all waste transfers, including details of the waste, carrier, and disposal location.
- Store waste securely: Ensure waste is stored safely and securely to prevent leaks, spills, or unauthorized access.
- Separate and recycle: Implement recycling programs and separate waste materials where appropriate.
- Ask questions about disposal: Inquire about how the waste will be handled and disposed of to ensure it's done legally and responsibly.
- Keep records: Retain records of waste transfers and other relevant documents for at least two years.

In addition to the Duty of Care, which applies to all wastes, there are extra duties that apply when waste is classed as hazardous.

The main duties that affect grab and support operations are:

Do

- Make sure that all hazardous wastes must be segregated from non-hazardous waste (i.e. it must not be mixed).
- Ensure that hazardous waste must be transported to recycling or disposal sites that are licenced to accept hazardous waste.

Don't

- Don't use unregistered waste carriers: avoid using individuals or companies not registered to handle waste.
- Don't dispose of commercial waste in household bins: commercial waste must be handled separately and cannot be disposed of with household waste.
- Don't accept unsolicited waste disposal offers: be cautious of individuals offering to take waste for free or at very low prices.
- Don't allow waste to be fly-tipped: take reasonable steps to prevent your waste from being illegally dumped.
- Don't ignore suspicious activity: if you suspect illegal waste disposal, report it to the appropriate authorities.
- Don't accept waste without proper documentation: if you are receiving waste, ensure the previous holder has met their duty of care obligations.

The “Street Works UK Protocol” outlines best practices and legal requirements for carrying out street works (utility work on roads and pavements) in the UK, focusing on safety and coordination.

From 30 September 2025, the Environment Agency (EA) is withdrawing RPS 298. All excavated waste must now be classified using a new EA-approved risk-based protocol.



To watch the SWUK Protocol step by step process, **click here** or scan QR code.

New protocol requirements

- Applies to Immediate, Minor, Standard, and some Major works (traffic-related only).
- Involves a desktop and site risk assessment.
- 1% of jobs must be lab tested (sampled on-site before transfer) – all sampling to be completed by the Client.
- All results must be logged in Street Manager and shared with EA via Street Works UK quarterly.

Do

- Carry out Site specific risk assessment (SRAs) **must** be completed using the following tools: Visual assessment; Smell assessment; Texture assessment and PAK marker spray (for asphalt only).
- These **must** be recorded on FYLD for most teams – make sure you know how to do it.
- The SRA **must** be completed once the excavation is complete and before moving on to the next stage of the job.
- The attached guidance is there to help and guide you, these requirements are not a nice to have they are a **must do**.

The main duties that affect grab and support operations are:

- All hazardous wastes must be segregated from non-hazardous waste (i.e. it must not be mixed).
- Hazardous waste must be transported to recycling or disposal sites that are licenced to accept hazardous waste.



Excavation Waste – Waste Classification Protocol – Segregation of excavation waste is now a mandatory site requirement not just good practice.

- Separate waste by type: Bituminous materials separate from backfill / soils giving clear space between them.
- Use PAK spray on the Bituminous layer (as per the guidance via QR code).
- Coal tar identifiers include: A strong odour of coal, ash, and smoke. Also, a deep black/dark brown colour.
- Complete your SRA.
- Identify the waste type red/hazardous and green / non-hazardous using the correct classification.
- If red / hazardous contact your supervisor for validation.
- They must be segregated on collection and on the back of the vehicle.
- Use designated skips or zones to prevent cross-contamination and make handling easier when back at depots.
- Reuse clean/inert materials on-site where permitted and safe to do so.
- Keep clear records –include waste types, transfer notes, volumes, and final disposal routes.

Collecting waste

Site specific risk assessment

When attending a site, it's important that site specific environmental risks are identified and assessed before waste collection or reinstatement commences.

For example, if there are trees near to the site, the grab may cause damage to them if operations aren't properly planned or controlled. Any further site specific risks that are identified should be assessed and appropriate control measures identified and recorded.

For many sites the team leader will have prepared a site specific risk assessment. The team leader should talk you through the risk assessment and any control measures that apply. You should check to ensure that the team's risk assessment covers any further risks created during collection of waste or reinstatement.

If the team are no longer present, a new site specific risk assessment should be prepared.

Inspect and classify waste

(EWC codes)



Explosive



Flammable



Acute toxicity



Oxidising



Corrosive



Health hazard / hazardous to the ozone layer



You'll see that the old 'harmful / irritant' symbol is missing. This has been replaced by the exclamation mark pictogram.

Where waste is transferred from one person to another, there's a legal duty that requires that the person transferring the waste must sign a declaration to confirm that the 'Waste Hierarchy' has been followed.

The Waste Hierarchy promotes the reduction, reuse and recycling of waste and thereby minimises the environmental impacts of disposal of waste to landfill.

All wastes throughout the UK are coded using a Europe-wide system known as the European Waste Catalogue (EWC). The EWC lists different waste types and gives each of them a unique six-digit code.

The EWC codes are used by waste producers to identify the type of waste on their waste transfer documentation. The EWC codes are also used by persons who hold a licence to help identify which types of waste they can legally deal with under their licence conditions - so called 'permitted wastes'.

Grab and support operators must visually inspect the waste they are picking up and decide on the type of waste and its correct EWC code. This code is then recorded on the Waste Transfer Note or Multi Site Waste Pickup Register.

The Contract Waste Matrix lists all recycling or disposal sites which are approved for contract waste and identifies the EWC codes for the permitted wastes that each site can legally accept. Grab operators must take the load to a recycling, transfer or landfill site that is permitted to accept the type of waste they are carrying. If wastes are wrongly coded, or are taken to a site that is not licenced for that type of waste, it's likely that the load will be rejected. So making sure that the correct code is used is important.

The most commonly encountered EWC codes for grab and support operations are:

Waste Description	EWC code
Asbestos cement pipes	17 06 05 *
Aerosols	15 01 10 *
Bituminous mixtures containing coal tar	17 03 01 *
Bituminous mixtures	17 03 02
Bricks	17 01 02
Concrete	17 01 01
Cardboard	15 01 01
General municipal waste	20 03 01
Metal	17 04 07
Mixed construction waste	17 09 04
Plastic	17 02 03
Soil and stones	17 05 04
Soil and stones containing asbestos	17 06 05 *
Spill kits, absorbents and oily waste	15 02 02 *
Wood	17 02 01
Wooden packaging	15 01 03

Storage of waste

It's the duty of all waste producers to prevent their waste escaping into the environment. The segregation of waste into separate containers or stockpiles can lead to lower costs by:

- Reducing disposal costs and landfill tax payments through preventing the contamination of inactive wastes by active wastes.
- Maximising the potential for reusing and recycling materials.
- Making it easier to see how much of each type of waste is being produced and hence where efforts to reduce waste need to be targeted.

Do

- Keep sites tidy and collect up any waste regularly.
- Use waste containers, skips or bays suitable for the type of waste being stored.
- Use skips with lids or cover them with sheets or nets to prevent dust and litter being blown out.
- Check that containers and skips aren't corroded or worn out to minimize the risk of accidental spillages or leaks.
- Mark waste stores clearly with their intended contents and ensure labels on containers are kept in good order.
- Segregate waste before putting it into the designated containers.

Don't

- Throw materials into the wrong container or stockpile.
- Contaminate one waste type with another.
- Overfill skips or bays.
- Give waste away, all waste taken off-site needs to be accompanied by paperwork.
- Damage covers over, or bunds around, any skips or containers.
- Burn or bury waste – it's illegal.

Delivery of waste for recycling or disposal

Completing waste transfer documentation

At the recycling or disposal site, you should check with the operator that your load is suitable for tipping.

If you're unsure whether you have correctly coded the waste, or aren't certain that they can accept some or your entire load, always ask before tipping. If they can accept your load, then complete this section of the Waste Transfer Note as follows:

Waste transfer / disposal site details (transferee)	
Site operator	
Site name	
Site address	
Site licence / exemption number	
On behalf of site operator	
Signature	
Name	
Date	
Time	

When you arrive at the disposal / recycling site, hand your form to the site operator or weighbridge operator for them to complete this section.

If they are happy to accept your waste, they should add in details of:

- Site Operator
 - Site Address,
 - Site Name
 - Site Licence / Exemption Number
- (This is important as it confirms that they hold a licence to accept waste).

Some sites have a stamp that the weighbridge operator will use to complete this section.

The representative of the disposal site MUST sign and date - make sure the name is legible.

Leave the Blue copy at the disposal site.

Now the form is complete you should keep it together with any tipping ticket / receipt issued by the disposal / recycling site and hand them in to your office for checking as soon as possible.

Checking records

Checking

Before handing in waste documentation to your office, check that all documents are legible and have been fully completed and that all documents relating to each transfer are together.

Correcting mistakes

If you notice that any parts of your documentation are incomplete or need to be changed, it's important that you ensure that all copies are amended, including the copy left at the recycling or disposal site.

Return to office

Hand in all waste documentation to your office frequently, at least weekly if possible. When your pre-printed books of transfer notes are complete, these should also be handed in to the office for filing.

All waste transfer documentation is required by law to be kept for at least two years.

Collecting recycled aggregate

Checking quality of recycled materials

To promote the recycling or reuse of waste construction materials, Waste and Resources Action Programme (the WRAP Protocol) has produced a Quality Protocol for recycled aggregates. The Protocol is important as it sets out standards for the manufacture of secondary (recycled) aggregates from waste. Where a producer follows the Protocol, this allows them to demonstrate that the secondary aggregates are suitable for use and comply with the relevant standards applying to the grades of materials they are supplying.

The Protocol requires that procedures are in place for the checking of wastes prior to processing to ensure they are compliant materials, then controlling the manufacturing process to ensure consistent quality of final products. If the Protocol is not followed, or if the final products do not conform to their specification, the Environment Agency and local highways authorities would regard the product as still being waste.

This would mean that anyone using such products would be in effect reinstating with waste and would therefore require an environmental permit covering their use. In any event if poor quality materials are used, the reinstatement may fail to meet the Specification for the Reinstatement of

Openings in Highways. This would make the use of non-compliant materials unlawful and risk costly remedial works to excavate and replace reinstated carriageway or footway.

When collecting recycled aggregates from a producer it's therefore essential that they supply the purchaser with documentation, including a description of the material, its industry specification and a statement to confirm that the aggregate was produced in accordance with the WRAP protocol. Most suppliers will provide this documentation on their collection/ delivery tickets. Grab drivers should therefore check that the materials they are collecting are correctly identified on the ticket and that there's a written confirmation that they have been manufactured under the quality protocol.

- Moisture content - too wet
- Particle size - too fine or too coarse
- Presence of non-aggregate contaminants - such as glass, plastic, metal or organic materials.

If you suspect that the material may not be compliant, contact your line manager for advice.

Waste management

Reduce, reuse, recycle

Reduction, reuse and recycling of waste minimises the environmental impacts of disposal of waste to landfill. To minimise waste we must:

- Firstly Prevent the waste if we can.
- Secondly Reuse waste materials and only then Recycle the waste.

Only if we can't recycle can we send them for Recovery, such as energy recovery and finally Dispose of the waste to landfill as a last resort.

Do

- Eliminate unnecessary wastage by storing materials neatly on flat solid ground to avoid damage and loss.
- Reduce the amount of waste you create on-site.
- Keep materials in their packaging for as long as possible to protect them from damage.
- Keep significant offcuts for use elsewhere.
- Reuse materials until no longer fit for purpose, for example, shuttering, fencing.
- Then reuse materials for alternative purposes, for example, use old shuttering ply for hoardings.

Don't

- Put waste materials into the wrong waste container.
- Open new cans or pallets before the ones in use are empty.
- Leave materials unprotected and where they are likely to be damaged by, for example, rain or mud.
- Burn or bury waste – it's illegal.
- Mix different types of waste – it prevents recycling.

Segregation of waste

Segregating waste into hazardous, non-hazardous and inert waste types for disposal can help minimise costs and maximise the opportunities for recovery and recycling of wastes.

It's illegal to mix hazardous waste with other waste types. You could be fined up to £50,000 and imprisoned for up to 5 years.

Incorrectly disposing of hazardous waste could cause water pollution and damage habitats. Landfills and waste treatment centres are specially designed to be able to handle specific wastes without causing environmental harm. Segregating wastes can minimise landfill tax and can also allow certain types of waste to be recycled and reused on site.

Do

- Segregate wastes into different types
- Use enclosed or covered skips or stockpile excavation wastes carefully
- Ask your line manager for advice if you're unsure about correct waste segregation on site.

Don't

- Mix different types of waste.
- Put liquids and flammable wastes (aerosols) into skips.

Wildlife and protected areas

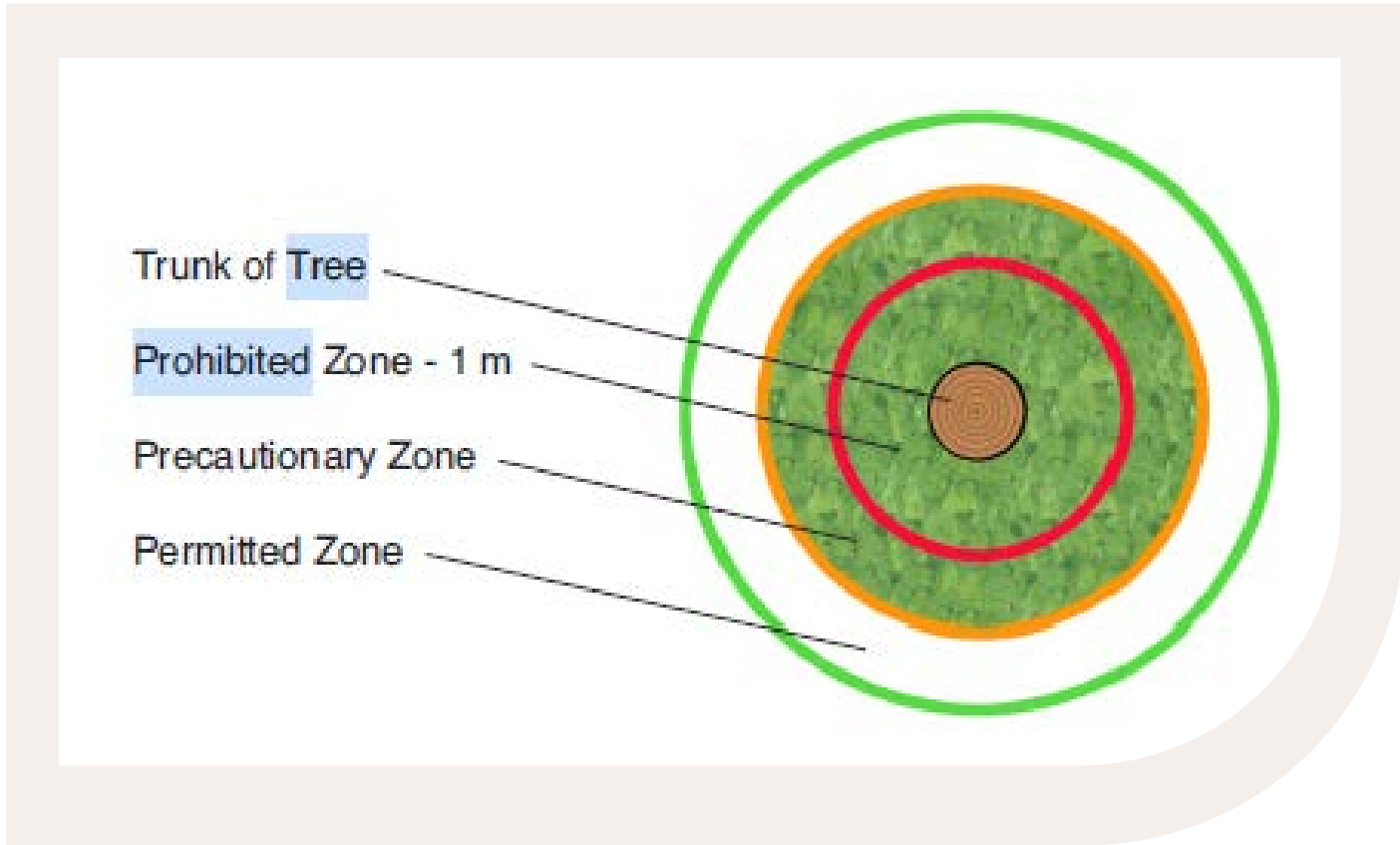
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Horticulture production land
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Why it's important

Trees and hedgerows provide a vitally important habitat for wildlife and many trees and hedgerows are protected by law.

It's illegal to cut down trees protected by law under a Tree Preservation Order or to grub up certain countryside hedges. During certain times of the year trees and hedgerows may contain nesting birds.

Nesting birds are protected by law against disturbance under the Wildlife and Countryside Act. Damaged trees may become unstable and potential hazards.



Do

- Check with your manager before felling any trees or removing any hedgerows.
- Clear only vegetation as instructed by your manager.
- Check for nesting birds and if any are found contact your manager immediately.
- Ask your manager what protection is required to trees and hedgerows.
- Check with your manager before excavating near to trees and hedgerows.
- Take photographs if there's any doubt.
- Remember the safe excavation zones:
 - All Prohibited Zone (1 m from trunk)
 - Precautionary Zone (4 x tree circumference)
 - Permitted Zone (outside the precautionary zone).

Don't

- Undertake tree felling or hedgerow clearance during the bird nesting season.
- Undertake any works to, or near to, trees without authorisation from your manager.
- Track vehicles or plant over tree protection areas.
- Store materials, especially fuels and oils, under or near trees.

Why it's important

Archaeology is the study of human history through the excavation of sites and the analysis of physical remains. Archaeology is an important part of our heritage and valuable and irreplaceable remains can easily be damaged on construction sites.

It's not only buildings and their foundations but also artefacts such as jewellery, pottery, coins, bones and skeletons that need expert examination before removal and preservation.

It's illegal to damage some monuments and archaeological structures.



Do

- Stop work if you find any archaeological features and immediately contact your manager for instructions.
- Obey the advice provided by any appointed archaeologist.

Don't

- Assume that any artefacts or features discovered are unimportant.
- Remove any 'finds' such as coins, pottery, or bones from the site, it's illegal.
- Undertake work adjacent areas of archaeological importance without considering if any damage may be caused.
- Cause vibration near to remains as this may cause cracking.
- Dewater as this may cause a preserved feature to settle and crack.
- Drive vehicles through protected sites.

Why it's important

Sites of Special Scientific Interest (SSSIs) are nationally important habitat areas that are legally protected. Many SSSIs are also internationally important and are protected under European legislation. An SSSI can be harmed in many ways, such as trampling, cutting vegetation, excavation or tipping waste. They may even be damaged by works some distance away, through for example noise, dust or water pollution.

It's illegal to undertake potentially damaging operations or disturb wildlife on or near a SSSI without consent from Natural England, Scottish Natural Heritage or Natural Resources Wales.

Prosecution could lead to a fine of up to £20,000 per offence and in some cases unlimited fines.

Do

- If working on or near an SSSI, check to find out why the area is important and what activities may cause damage to it.
- Only undertake works that have been given consent by the regulator.
- Restore the works area to the condition it was in before works started.
- Replant using only approved species that are native to the site.
- Keep noise, dust and silt to a minimum if working within 250m of an SSSI.
- Take photographs of work areas before, during and after works are completed.

Don't

- Clear vegetation unless you have permission.
- Remove any SSSI signs.
- Use pesticides or tip any waste in or near an SSSI.
- Spread seeds or other plant matter within an SSSI.
- Pump silty water across an SSSI.
- Remove any plant or animal from the site.
- Alter drainage arrangements in any way, even improving drainage could harm wildlife.
- Use vehicles that are likely to damage the area, such as heavy plant.



Why it's important

There are 16 species of bat in the UK, many are endangered. Bats are a legally protected species.

It's a criminal offence for anyone to:

- Intentionally kill, injure or handle a bat
- Possess a bat (whether live or dead)
- Disturb a roosting bat

Damage, destroy or obstruct access to any place used by bats for shelter, whether they are present or not.

Breaking the law can lead to fines of up to £5,000 per bat and/or up to 6 months in prison.

Since they tend to return to the same roosts each year, these sites are also protected whether the bats are present or not. Places where you might find bats include holes and cracks in trees, roofs and walls of houses and buildings, under bridges, underground in caves and old railway tunnels.

Every building and mature tree is a potential bat roost. Look out for bat droppings – dark brown or black, about 4 to 8mm in length. They look like mouse droppings but crumble easily, as they are made up of insect fragments. In well-established roosts, droppings may be several centimetres deep.

Do

- If you think you have found a bat or a bat roost on site, **immediately** stop all works in the area and inform your line manager.

Don't

- Try to touch or handle a bat. They are very delicate, and you are very likely to cause them serious harm – **it is also breaking the law.**



Why it's important

Badgers are a legally protected species. Both the animals and their setts are protected by law.

It's a criminal offence to:

- Kill, injure or take a badger
- Disturb a badger when it's occupying a sett
- Interfere with a badger sett by damaging or destroying it
- Obstruct the access to, or any entrance of a badger sett.

It's illegal to carry out any construction work close to a badger sett without taking steps to positively avoid damage and without an appropriate Licence.

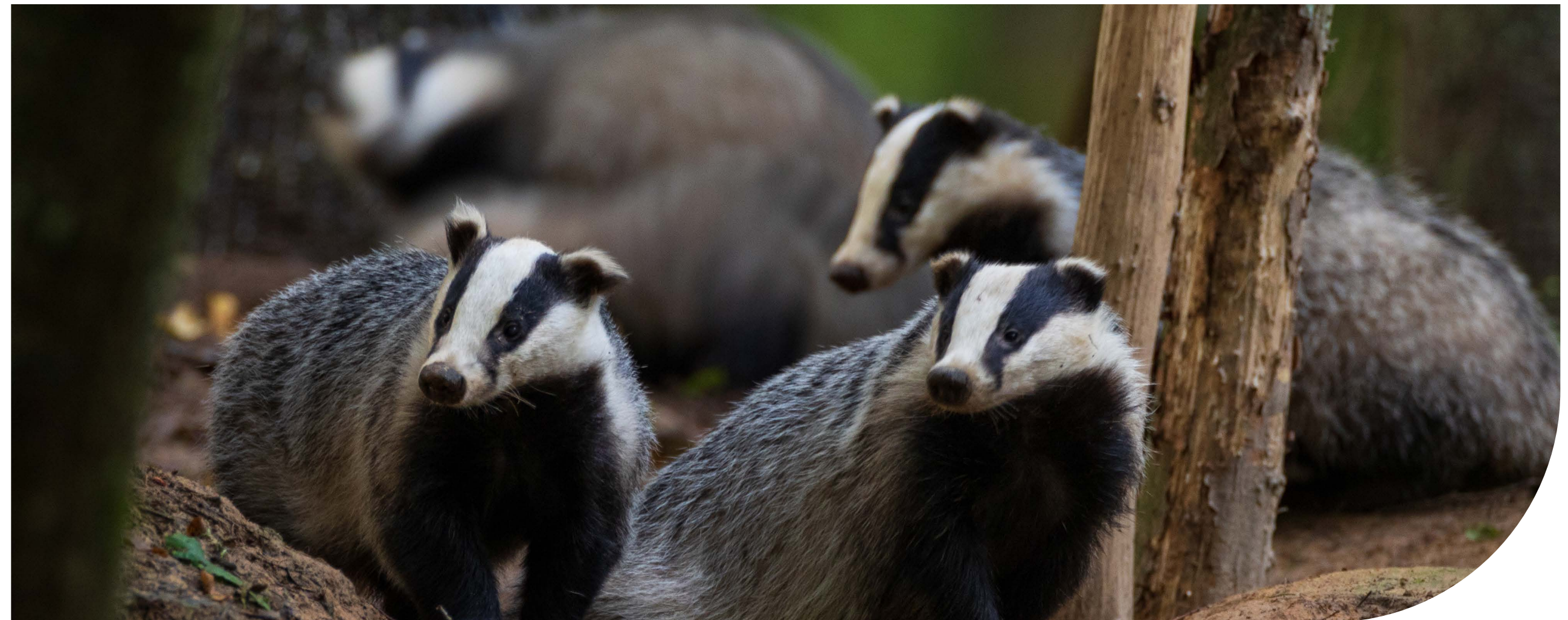
It's no excuse in law to be unaware of the presence of Badgers. Most badgers have the characteristic black and white striped face although very occasionally they can be creamy white (albino) or red/ginger in colour. Fully grown adults can be up to 1 metre in length and weigh up to 14 kg. The sett entrance is usually D shaped and at around 300mm wide by 200mm high is larger than either a fox or rabbit hole. There may be signs of freshly excavated material at the entrance or piles of leaves, dry grass, straw or bracken, which the badgers take inside to use as bedding.

Do

Immediately stop work and inform your line manager if you discover a badger sett or see a badger on your site.

Don't

- Use heavy machines within 30 metres.
- Use light machines within 20 metres.
- Hand dig or clear scrub within 10 metres of a badger sett before checking with your line manager whether a licence is necessary.



Great Crested Newts

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Why it's important

The Great Crested Newt is the largest and the rarest of the 3 species of newts found in the UK. Their numbers have been declining rapidly over the past thirty years due to loss of habitat.

They live in ponds and very slow moving watercourses but are also found in woodland, scrub, hedgerows, rough grass land and derelict sites surrounding ponds and watercourses.

It's an offence to:

- Intentionally or recklessly kill, injure, capture, trade or even to disturb a Great Crested Newt.
- Damage, destroy or obstruct habitats where Great Crested Newts live or breed.

Prosecution could lead to a fine of up to £5000 per newt affected and in some cases up to 6 months imprisonment.

They grow to around 170mm (almost 7 inches) in length with a rough, granular skin. Back and flanks are brownish black with darker spots.

Vivid orange or yellow belly has an irregular pattern of black spots or blotches. Males have jagged crest on the back with a smoother edged crest above and below the tail and white, silver or grey stripe running from the tail tip, fading as it reaches the abdomen. **Females don't have a crest and have a yellow-orange stripe running along the lower edge of the tail.**

Do

Stop work in the immediate area and contact your manager for instruction if you think you have identified Great Crested Newts on your site.

- Watch out when moving logs, stones or rubble or clearing the site near to ponds. These are favourite habitats for Great Crested Newts.

Don't

- Try to touch or otherwise disturb any Great Crested Newt.



Biosecurity In The Countryside

With a vast network of utility services crisscrossing 17 million hectares of the UK’s agriculture, factory floor of food and drink production. This environment in 2024 contributed £14.5bn to the UK economy.

There is a responsibility to understand the biosecurity implications associated with project work in this environment.

Why it’s important

Biosecurity refers to measures aimed at preventing the introduction or spread of harmful organisms (e.g. viruses, bacteria, plants, animals, etc.) intentionally or unintentionally outside their native range or within new environment. In agriculture, these measures are aimed at protecting food crops and livestock from diseases, pest and invasive species.



Do

- Ensure footwear is clean (visually free from soil and debris). If necessary, brush or wash in soapy water.
- Ensure vehicle is kept clean and remove any accumulated mud.
- Make use of any facilities provided at the premises to clean footwear if required by the site or land manager.
- Keep access to a minimum, do not access areas unnecessarily and if practical do not take vehicles onto premises and keep to established tracks.
- Respect any notices and instruction.

If you are entering farmland or parts of a farm building where livestock may be present or crops grown, the risk of spreading disease increases and you need to take some extra precautions.

- Clean and disinfect footwear.
- If vehicle has entered an area where livestock have access, ensure the tyres and wheel arches are adequately cleaned and disinfected.

Don’t

- Enter a farm premises without contacting the owner.
- Enter farm premises without cleaning / disinfecting footwear.
- Touch or feed livestock.
- Leave farm gates open.
- Do not touch or pick up sick or dead wild birds, as they can carry diseases infectious to human per Avian Influenza (Bird Flu).
- Dispose of disinfectant near watercourse or surface water drains.
- Use same disinfectant batch for multi farm visits. Make a new batch per farm visit.

Disinfectants: Which one?

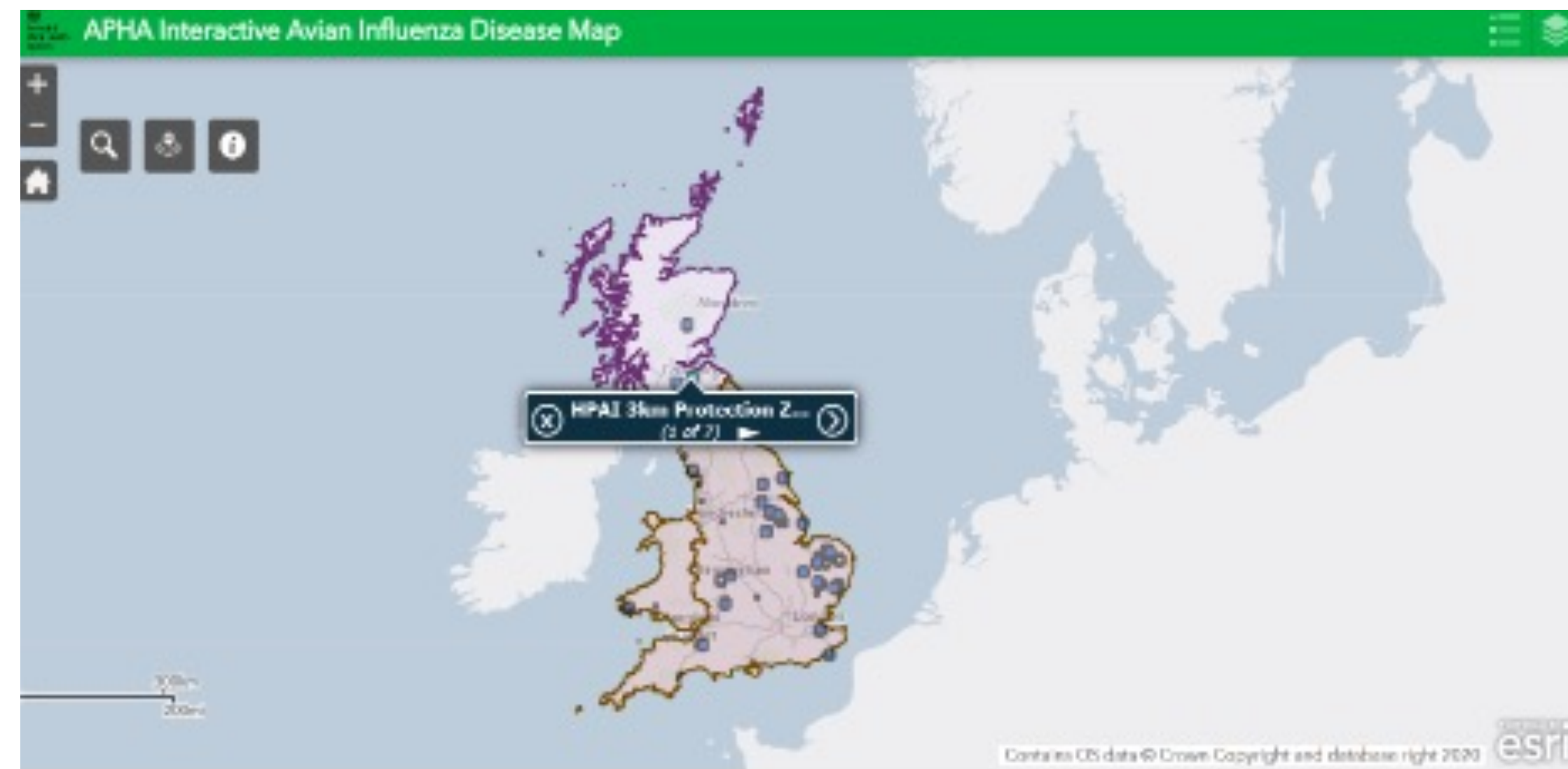
Use DEFRA-approved disinfectants based on disease type prevention (e.g., Avian Influenza, Tuberculosis). A list of approved disinfectants can be found at: **Disinfectants approved for use in England, Scotland and Wales.**



Notifiable Disease Outbreak Avian Influenza (AI) Bird Flu UK 2025/2026

The following link will take you to the most up to date information of confirmed outbreaks location and disease enforcement zones:

- Avian Influenza case DEFRA, APHA disease outbreak map – **APHA Interactive Avian Influenza Disease Map.**
- The disease impacts all poultry from urban back garden pets, racing pigeons to commercial flocks and the wild bird population.
- The PDF declaration per outbreak zone directs the associated biosecurity requirements.



Dead, sick and or injured wild birds

**Do not touch or pick up any dead or visibly sick birds that you find.
Wild birds can carry several diseases that are infectious to people.**

In Great Britain, if you find at the same time:

- A single dead bird of prey, swan, goose, duck, or gull or
- Five or more dead wild birds of any other species you should report them on gov.uk's **report dead wild bird's page**.

Alternatively, you can phone the helpline:
03459 335 577.

Sick or injured wild birds

Report an injured/sick bird to the:

- Royal Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals: (RSPCA) **03001 234 999**
- or
- Scottish Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (SSPCA) **03000 999 999**

Biosecurity: plant health

There is a high risk of potential transference of pests and diseases via infested soil, plant vegetation debris, mechanical equipment, clothing, and footwear in association with project work.

Establish if there are any plant health biosecurity measures required by the landowner.

Two diseases that have major impact on agriculture production are **Potato Cyst Nematode** and **Clubroot**. There is no production allowed where Nematodes are present of certain crops. Additionally, clubroot presence effectively can make it non-economical viable to produce some crop types.

To mitigate follow the biosecurity measures

- Ensuring all mechanical equipment and footwear is clean prior and post entering the land which may further extend to cleaning between each field pending the extent of work on the farm.
- Excavated soil remains in the same location, no redistribution and if appropriate imported topsoil is tested prior as required.
- Keep records that include dates, and photographic evidence of cleaning and disinfectant of equipment undertaken.

To note, both diseases can be detected via soil testing pre and post project works.

Nematode cyst on potato roots (magnified image).



Oilseed Rape plant Clubroot infested image.

Why it's important

It's illegal “to plant or otherwise encourage” the growth or spread of invasive plants, such as Japanese Knotweed, Himalayan Balsam or Giant Hogweed.

They spread quickly, dominate habitats, grow densely and shade out native plants. Biodiversity is affected as the consequent loss in plant diversity leads to a reduction in the population of insects and birds.

Japanese knotweed forms dense clumps over 3m high. The rhizome roots can extend several metres away from the original plant and be up to 2m deep. The plant is strong enough to penetrate foundations, walls, roads and drainage pipework. It spreads through progression of its root system and through fragments of its stem or root (a piece as small as 0.8 grams can regenerate). The stem is hollow with distinct nodes like bamboo and breaks easily.

In Spring it's fleshy and red tinged and in Summer it's green with purple speckles. Leaves in Spring are pinky red and uncurl as the stem grows. In Summer they become large oval or heart shaped mid-green.

Flowers are cream coloured and appear in drooping clusters towards the end of August. The plant dies before November often leaving behind the upright brown, hollow, woody stalks.

Do

Immediately stop all work within 7 metres of the suspect plant and contact your line manager for instructions if you think you have identified japanese knotweed on your site.

Don't

- Excavate or move any soil from within 7 metres of a Japanese Knotweed plant without instruction.
- Track plant or vehicles over the area.
- Stockpile potentially contaminated material within 10 metres of a watercourse or drain.



Other invasive plants

Himalayan Balsam

Himalayan Balsam produces more than 500 seeds before it dies. The slightest touch to seed pods causes them to burst open catapulting and dispersing the seeds up to 7m away. It grows up to 2.5m tall and the stem is pinky red, hollow, sappy and brittle.

Leaves occur in two's or three's from the same point on the stem, are spear shaped with serrated edges, shiny and dark green with a reddish mid-rib.

Flowers, which are similar to a Foxglove, are purplish pink, carried on long stalks and appear from June to October.



Giant Hogweed

Giant Hogweed is now wide spread throughout the UK. It grows to over 5m tall. The seeds can remain viable on or in the ground for up to 15 years.

The plant contains large amounts of poisonous sap, which, on contact with the skin and in the presence of sunlight, causes severe irritation, swelling and painful watery blisters. This reaction can occur up to 24 hours after exposure to sunlight. Contact with eyes can cause temporary blindness.

Giant Hogweed can cause significant harm to grazing animals.

Do

- Stop work in the immediate area and contact your manager for instruction if you think you have identified either Himalayan Balsam or Giant Hogweed on your site.**
- Wear protective clothing before touching Giant Hogweed and seek medical advice if you have been in contact with the sap.

Don't

- Disturb the seedpods.
- Move soil that may contain seeds or other plant materials without specific instructions.
- Handle Giant Hogweed until further advice is taken.





M GROUP

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Essential infrastructure
services for life